

non-compliance with these open source licences. OSPO handles open source software right from its on-boarding till the time it is delivered to the end user and everything inbetween, irrespective of whether it is being used for internal or external purposes.

An OSPO builds a solid foundation by starting compliance and regulatory checks in the early software development life cycle. This usually begins by guiding and aligning the involved team members towards a common path that benefits the organisation's values. The OSPO puts in place policies and processes around open source usage and governs the roles and responsibilities across the company.

To conclude, it aligns the efforts of all relevant teams involved in building the product and helps increase the organisation's capacity for better and effective use of open source.

The function of an OSPO

The function of an OSPO may vary from organisation to organisation depending on the number of its employees and the number of people that are part of the OSPO team. Another factor is the purpose of using open source. An organisation may only want to use open source software for building the product or may also look at contributing back to the community.

Evaluating factors such as which open source licences are appropriate or whether full-time employees should be contributing to an open source project may be part of the OSPO's role. Putting a contributor licence agreement (CLA) in place for developers that are willing to contribute and determining what open source components will help in accelerating a product's growth and quality are some other roles of an OSPO.

Some of the key functions of an OSPO involve:

- Putting an open source compliance and governance policy in place to mitigate intellectual property risks to the organisation

- Educating developers towards better decision-making
- Defining policies that lay out the requirements and rules for working with open source across the company
- Monitoring the usage of open source software inside as well as outside the organisation
- Conducting meetings after every software release to discuss what went well and what could be done better with the OSS compliance process
- Accelerating the software development life cycle (SDLC)
- Transparency and coordination amongst different departments
- Streamlining processes to help mitigate risks at an early stage
- Encouraging members to contribute upstream to gain the collaborative and innovative benefits of open source projects
- Producing a report with suitable remediation and recommendations for the product team
- Preparing compliance artifacts and ensuring licence obligations are fulfilled

Building an OSPO

The OSPO is typically staffed with personnel from multiple departments within the company. The process involves training and educating the relevant departments regarding open source compliance basics and the risks involved in its usage. It may provide legal and technical support services so that the open source requirement goals are met.

An OSPO may be formed by the following people within the organisation (this is a non-exhaustive list of people who can be a part of it):

- **Principal/Chief:** This role can be taken by the flag bearer, the one who runs the OSPO. The chief knows the various aspects of using open source like the effect of using different components, licence implications, development and contributing to the community. These requirements are entirely dependent on an organisation's needs.
- **Program manager:** The program manager sets the requirements and objectives for the target solution. He/she works alongside the product and engineering teams to

The rise of the OSPO

Companies like Microsoft, Google and Netflix have well established OSPOs within their organisations. Many others, like Porsche and Spotify, are building their own OSPOs to leverage the usage of open source in an efficient way.

Here is what leaders from renowned companies have to say about OSPO practices.

- "As a business, it's a culture change," explains Jeff McAffer, who ran Microsoft's Open Source Program Office for years and now is a director of products at GitHub focused on promoting open source in enterprises. "Many companies, they're not used to collaboration. They're not used to engaging with teams outside of their company."
- "Engineering, business, and legal stakeholders each have their own goals and roles, oftentimes making trade-offs between speed, quality, and risk," explains Remy DeCausemaker, head of open source at Spotify. "An OSPO works to balance and connect these individual goals into a holistic strategy that reduces friction."
- Gil Yahuda, Verizon Media's OSPO leader, states, "We seek to create a working environment that talent wants to be part of. Our engineers know that they work in an open source friendly environment where they are supported and encouraged to work with the open source communities that are relevant to their work."